UNJUST VEGAN
A Conceptual Reconstruction of Veganism

This text pursues a single aim: to trace the conceptual development of veganism and to articulate the underlying concept in contemporary language. It does not offer a general theory of the human–animal relationship, formulate a comprehensive ethical theory, or claim historical completeness. Where historical facts may be inaccurately presented, corrections are explicitly welcome. Interpretations, by contrast, are deliberately kept separate from verifiable textual and conceptual shifts.

Veganism is a term that is used very frequently and yet rarely understood with precision in contemporary debates. This is not due to any inherent vagueness of the concept itself, but to historical overlayering: over the decades, a wide range of meanings, aims, and moral framings have been added to what was originally a clearly delineated principle, increasingly obscuring its core.

Veganism is the principle that humans ought to live without exploiting animals.

The early texts on veganism from the 1940s and 1950s - most notably the theoretical writings of Leslie Cross - present a remarkably consistent picture. Veganism is not conceived there as a virtue ideal, not as the moral perfection of the human being (references to cultural or moral progress function merely as contextual reflections on the consequences of veganism), and not as a theory of justice. Rather, it is articulated as a clear, negative moral boundary: the renunciation of the claimed right to use animals.

What is central here is not how well humans act, but what they refrain from doing. Veganism is not formulated as a positive blueprint for a better human being, but as a refusal of domination in order to allow freedom. In this context, Cross explicitly speaks of the necessity of abandoning the idea that humans have a right to dispose of the lives of other sentient beings. This refusal is principled: it does not depend on utility, compassion, or moral maturity. At its core, Cross anchors this moral boundary in animal sentience.

It is striking that Cross embeds his writings within a broader historical and moral horizon. He speaks of social development, of humanisation, and of progress in moral insight. This framing is understandable in its historical context. What is decisive, however, is that this framing does not define the conceptual meaning of veganism. It serves to explain the historical significance of its consequences, not its substantive content.

In later reception, these distinctions and the original conceptual precision were increasingly blurred. What functions as context in Cross's writings becomes substance in later theorists. What the Vegan Society initially adopted as a conceptually precise definition was subsequently dissected into a linguistically non-functional and semantically empty formulation, thereby rendered open to arbitrary overlay and semantic drift.

Veganism is now commonly read as a justice movement, a strategic project, or an expression of personal ethical maturity. This shift is particularly evident in the alignment of veganism with broad evaluative concepts such as "justice," "decency," or "ethical integrity." What emerges is a fundamentally different concept that nevertheless continues to be labelled 'veganism.' The most dominant and consequential transformation is the reconfiguration of veganism into a matter of justice.

Justice is - historically as well as conceptually - a relational category. It operates within a shared normative framework and presupposes processes of weighing, attribution, and authority. Freedom, by contrast, marks a limit to such attributions. In the early vegan texts,

freedom is not understood as the outcome of a just distribution, but as a prior condition: the acceptance that another animal is not an object of human purposes and is to be free.

> The term “justice” is commonly used in everyday language where what is actually meant is simply a moral evaluation.
>
> As a result, justice comes to function as a general synonym for “morally right.”
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> This conceptual conflation is not harmless: it obscures questions of authority and presents justice either as a universal moral principle or as morality itself, even though the concept is structurally something else.

When veganism is primarily understood as a project of justice, the focus inevitably shifts from animals to humans, and from an absolute boundary to questions of correct decision-making, appropriate intervention, and morally “justifiable” use. It is precisely here that a space reopens in which control, management, and paternalistic interventions once again become defensible - no longer openly, but in the name of a purportedly higher moral good. The absurdity of this becomes clear when one recalls the original concept.

The conceptual clarity of veganism lays precisely in closing off this space. Veganism does not call for better decisions about animals; it fundamentally calls into question the right to make such decisions at all. In this sense, veganism is not a demanding or cumbersome concept. It is precise, lean, and unambiguous. What is difficult is not to comprehend or understand it, but to accept it. And it is precisely this difficulty that appears, historically, to have driven numerous modifications, extensions, reinterpretations, and moral embellishments.

What is decisive, then, is a return to conceptual clarity - not in order to end debates, but to place them on a clear foundation. Those who wish to speak about ethics, justice, or moral virtue can and should do so. But not by overloading the concept of veganism itself with meanings it does not bear.

In its origin, veganism is not a comprehensive moral theory. It is a principle of demarcation. Everything else lies outside its conceptual core.

In 1979, the Vegan Society itself dissolved the original definition and replaced it with a linguistically non-functional formulation. This made it possible for contemporary theoretical frameworks concerning the human-animal relationship to be imported into the discourse on veganism and animal liberation. Because the original concept had been forgotten and was no longer widely known, these efforts at theoretical redefinition were regarded as a meaningful achievement. In the 1990s, the concerns of animals were increasingly interpreted as a matter of justice, and by the year 2000 the term veganism itself had been recast as a justice-based project.

Today, there are only a few people worldwide who engage seriously with the original texts at all. And even among those who do, there often appears to be little recognition that associating veganism with justice ultimately works to the detriment of animals, because it renders veganism itself ad absurdum - while simultaneously claiming to have rediscovered it in fidelity to its original formulation.

In order to demonstrate this shift in meaning not merely as a conceptual claim, but as a historically traceable development, it is necessary to examine the key texts and contexts within the discourse itself. The following sections therefore consider central writings in

chronological order - not with the aim of providing comprehensive interpretations, but to show where and how the conceptual framework was gradually displaced: from a negative principle of limitation toward a project of justice.

1944 - *The Vegan News*, Donald Watson

The term *vegan* was introduced in 1944 with the launch of *The Vegan News, the quarterly magazine of the non-dairy vegetarians*.

"As this first issue of our periodical had to be named, I have used the title *The Vegan News*."[1]

The formation of the term *vegan* is explained retrospectively by Leslie Cross in an article in *The Vegan*: the term *vegan* was formed from the beginning and end of the word *vegetarian*, in order to mark a clear conceptual break.[2]

1951 – *The Vegan*, Vegan Society (*Veganism Defined*, Leslie Cross)

The text *Veganism Defined* contains a clear theoretical articulation of the concept of veganism. What is immediately striking is what does not occur in this text: neither a theory of just distribution nor a virtue-based account is developed. Instead, veganism is defined as a principled rejection of a specific relation - namely, the relation of use.

Central to this articulation is the emphasis that veganism takes as its point of departure the assumption that humans have a right over the lives of other sentient beings. This boundary is explicitly not dependent on degrees of suffering, calculations of utility, or levels of moral maturity. Nor is it conceived as the outcome of a just balance, but rather as its precondition: only where use itself is rejected can freedom be said to exist (within the context of veganism, "use" denotes any form of human use of animal life).

Although Cross frequently frames his argument in a language of historical progress and the moral development of humanity, this framing is explanatory rather than definitional. It describes possible consequences of veganism, not its conceptual core. In its foundational formulation, veganism is not an instrument of moral improvement, but a clear, principled limitation of human claims of authority.

"Veganism, however, is a principle - that man has no right to exploit creatures for his own ends - and no variation occurs."

"In a vegan world, creatures would be reintegrated within the balance and sanity of nature as she is in herself."

"A great and historic wrong, whose effect upon the course of evolution must have been stupendous, would be righted. The idea that fellow creatures might be used by man for self-interested purposes would be so alien to human thought as to be almost unthinkable. In this light, veganism is not so much welfare as liberation - liberation for the creatures, and for the mind and heart of man; not so much an effort to make the present relationship bearable, but an uncompromising recognition that because it is in the main one of master and slave, it has to be abolished before something better and finer can be built."[3]

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[1] Donald Watson, "The Vegan News," *The Vegan News*, Vol. 1 No. 1, 1944.
[2] Leslie Cross, "In Search of Veganism I," *The Vegan*, Vegan Society, 1949.
[3] Leslie Cross, "Veganism Defined," *The Vegan*, Vegan Society, 1951.

1975 – *Animal Liberation*, Peter Singer

Peter Singer's *Animal Liberation* is not a text about animal liberation in the narrower sense or veganism, yet it has had a significant influence on the subsequent shift in meaning. Singer interprets the moral relevance of animals within a utilitarian framework of justice. Liberation is not understood here as a limitation of human claims, but as the outcome of a just balancing of interests.

Accordingly, the discussion is confined to the question under which conditions the use of animals by humans can be morally justified. Although Singer himself does not address the concept of veganism, his theory decisively shapes the framework within which veganism is subsequently read.

"If a being suffers, there can be no moral justification for refusing to take that suffering into consideration."

Although Singer explicitly introduces the term *sentience*, he does so in a deliberately restricted sense. By stating that he "uses the term sentience to cover the capacity to suffer or experience enjoyment," he reduces sentience to a single functional property. What is lost in this reduction is precisely what earlier vegan texts treated as decisive: that sentient beings are not objects of legitimate human use, but mark a limit to such claims rather than merely entering the domain of moral consideration.

This shift toward a justice-based framing is further reinforced by the introduction of the concept of *speciesism*. Peter Singer defines speciesism as "the prejudice or attitude of bias in favor of the interests of members of one's own species and against those of members of other species." The term itself, however, was coined earlier by Richard Ryder in 1970. From its inception, speciesism thus enters the discourse as a discrimination concept, structurally analogous to racism and sexism. Rather than marking a prior limit to legitimate human use, it reframes animal exploitation as a problem of unequal consideration within a shared moral order.

"The word 'speciesism' is not an attractive one, but I can think of no better term for the prejudice or attitude of bias in favor of the interests of members of one's own species and against those of members of other species."[4]

1979 – *The Vegan Society Memorandum of Association*

With the 1979 memorandum, the Vegan Society itself effects a decisive rupture. The original conceptual clarity is dissolved and replaced by a formulation that is neither linguistically functional, meaning-determining, nor conceptually clear. The later introduction of an additional qualification ("as far as is possible and practicable") further shifts the focus away from principled grounding toward application, and from boundary-setting toward balancing.

This revision does not mark a merely linguistic change, but a structural opening of the concept. Veganism is no longer understood as the unambiguous negation of a claim to use animals, but as a negotiable practice within existing moral frameworks. Only through this conceptual derailment does it become possible to integrate external theories - utilitarian, rights-based, or strategic - under the name of veganism.

[4] Peter Singer, *Animal Liberation*, 1975; Chapter 1, "All Animals Are Equal".

“Veganism is a philosophy and way of living which seeks to exclude - as far as is possible and practicable - all forms of exploitation of, and cruelty to, animals.”[5]

Focus lies on the subordinate clause here. If you reduce the definition to its basic linguistic structure, this is what you get:

Main clause:

Veganism is a philosophy and way of living.

Subordinate clause:

[A] way of living which seeks to exclude.

The word “which” refers exclusively to “way of living” - because of the sentence structure, it cannot refer to “veganism”; also “seeks” is singular. The focus clearly lies on “way of living.”

Basic structure of the sentence:

A way of living seeks to exclude.

To illustrate how odd this is, an equivalent example would be: “A writing style tries to bring its alibis.”

‘Way of living’ only refers to a pattern of behaviour. A pattern cannot have a goal - it is itself the result of something. Only moral agents or principles can have goals. A way of living is the outcome of decisions, not the carrier of an intention.

A way of living is the result of decisions. So what guides those decisions? The “philosophy”? The attempt to exclude something? No, the attempt to exclude is already the pattern being described… It simply makes no sense at all. The sentence is non-functional and leaves open what the meaning of “vegan” is.

If a way of living could have an intention, then every observed habit would be its own moral agent. That is linguistically, conceptually, ontologically, and practically impossible.

The 1979 definition sounds reasonable. And that’s exactly the problem. It is “reasonable” in a way almost everyone finds normal. A “pseudo-definition”: linguistically vague and non-functional, without clear structure, stylistically “respectable”. Vagueness with a consequence: when a definition is unclear, anything can be read into it. And that is exactly what we can observe today.

1983 – *The Case for Animal Rights*, Tom Regan

Here, animals are explicitly integrated into a system of justice. As “subjects-of-a-life,” animals become bearers of rights within a moral community. Freedom appears not as a prior limit, but as a right that is to be recognised and protected within a justice framework conceived by humans.

In this way, the fundamental boundary demanded by veganism in earlier texts is ignored and bypassed within the discourse on human-animal relations. The central question is no longer whether humans have the right to use animals, but which rights animals ought to have within

[5] Vegan Society: *MEMORANDUM OF ASSOCIATION OF THE VEGAN SOCIETY,* 1979.

human conceptions of justice. Animal liberation thus becomes, implicitly, a project of just inclusion.

With Tom Regan's *The Case for Animal Rights*, the classification of animals as rights-bearing subjects within a human system of justice is explicitly established.

1996/2015: *Rain Without Thunder* / *Animal Rights – The Abolitionist Approach* (Gary Francione)

Gary Francione presents himself as a critic of welfarist approaches and as a proponent of an abolitionist position. Nevertheless, he also explicitly binds veganism to a concept of justice. In his account, veganism becomes a moral obligation: to recognise animals as rights-bearing subjects within our system of justice and to understand their exploitation as an injustice.

Even if it may superficially appear that this marks a return to the original conception of veganism, the discussion in fact takes place within a shifted conceptual framework. Freedom is here understood as the goal of just enforcement, rather than as a prior limit on human claims. This conceptualisation legitimises the power to define animals in the name of justice.

Francione explicitly situates veganism within a justice-based framework. Animals are described as "members of the moral community," and veganism is framed as "a moral obligation" and "the moral baseline of the animal rights position." Freedom here appears not as a prior limit to human authority, but as the outcome of just recognition and enforcement.

"Sentient beings have interests. Interests are the basis of moral rights. To say that a being has moral rights is to say that we are morally obligated to respect those interests."

"As long as animals are property, their interests will always be subordinated to the interests of their owners."

"If animals have rights, we cannot justify treating them as resources, no matter how 'humane' the treatment may be."

"If animals have moral rights, then veganism is not a matter of personal choice or lifestyle preference; it is a moral requirement."

"To exclude animals from the moral community while acknowledging their sentience is arbitrary and inconsistent."[6]

In condensed 2015 presentation the internal logic of the claims is briefly rehearsed: sentience grounds interests, interests ground rights, and rights are incompatible with the treatment of animals as property. Within this framework, the abolition of animal use is treated as a moral requirement, later articulated as "veganism". What remains unaddressed is not the coherence of this reasoning, but the prior question of whether framing the human-animal relation in terms of justice and rights is itself conceptually sound.

[6] Gary Francione and Anna Charlton, *Introduction to Animal Rights* , 2015, Chapters 1,2 & 6.

What else if not justice?

The ambition to include animals within our moral community may appear unambiguously positive, yet it is neither feasible nor conceptually coherent. Justice presupposes a shared horizon of meaning. Animals do not stand within that horizon. Applying justice to them is therefore not inclusion, but domination.

Animals are morally relevant because they are sentient and therefore vulnerable. Between humans and animals, there is no shared normative order and no reciprocal community of justice. Where reciprocity (of normative order) is impossible and power is asymmetrical, justice is the wrong category. What arises there is not a duty to establish a just order, but a duty of restraint.

Freedom is not recognition and not a judgement. It is simply the absence of domination - the acceptance of freedom.

It is important to stress that excluding animals from our moral community does not imply denying them moral relevance. It simply means refraining from subsuming them under our moral order and from claiming definitional authority over them.